



Times of uncertainty: With India having no wins and also losing its Intercontinental Cup crown this year, along with facing a future without Sunil Chhetri, the football scene in the country has never been grimmer. AIFF MEDIA

A TEAM IN THE DOLDRUMS

A draw with lower-ranked Malaysia marked a **winless calendar year** for India for the first time since 2006.

At times, the lows in sports are so low that they evoke pity rather than optimism. Indian football, specifically the senior men's team, has endured such a phase this year.

With India having no wins and also losing the Intercontinental Cup crown this calendar year, along with facing a future without its record goalscorer Sunil Chhetri, the football scene in the country has never been grimmer.

The final act of this dismal saga unfolded in a draw with lower-ranked Malaysia at the GMC Balayogi Stadium in Hyderabad, on a day when the match atmosphere felt more like a school sports day than an international football encounter.

Two hours before kick-off, the venue saw school children queuing up and trickling into the stadium, while fans of the home team were scarcely in sight.

Even though a few arrived later, many others remained tied to

their work commitments, unable to attend the match on a Monday evening.

Among those absent was P. Srikanth, an auto-rickshaw driver who had travelled earlier with the Diary in the hopes of watching India practice.

"Malaysia tomorrow, no? I worked there for a few years but came back during the pandemic," he said. When asked who he would support, he chuckled and replied, "India, *bhai*," in his distinct Hyderabad accent.